



Finnish Environment Institute's (Syke) Action Plan for the Responsible Assessment of Research and Researchers 2025-2028

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by Syke's Operational Management Group



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Finnish Environment Institute's (Syke) action plan for the responsible assessment of research and researchers 2025-2028

Syke's current state in research assessment

The assessment of research at the Finnish Environment Institute (Syke) is primarily guided by Syke's strategy and the performance agreements with the Ministry of the Environment and the Ministry of Agriculture and Forestry. The research targets are derived from the strategy and the performance and impact targets agreed upon in the performance agreements. The implementation of the strategy and performance targets are monitored at the organizational level. Researchers are evaluated based on the annual goals agreed upon by the supervisor and the researcher, as well as in connection of recruitments. The assessment is described in more detail in Table 1 below.

The vision of Syke's strategy is a sustainability transformation, and its mission is to support the building of a sustainable society with research, information, and services. Syke produces knowledge and solutions to promote the sustainability transformation. Approximately 60% of Syke's funding is used for research and development activities, and 25% for expert work.

Syke's strategic ways of operating include following the principles of open data and science, proactively maintaining high level of expertise, and continuously improving operations. Syke's values include ethical conduct, inclusion, fairness, and equality.

Syke is committed to the principles of good research practice and the national declaration for open science and research, including responsible assessment and the recommendation for the responsible evaluation of a researcher in Finland ([Declaration for Open Science and Research 2020-2025 | Open Science](#)). Syke has signed the international agreement on reforming research assessment and is committed to its principles ([The Agreement - CoARA](#)).

Organizational level assessment

Syke is a research and development center under the Ministry of the Environment, which sets performance targets for Syke. Syke is also performance-guided by the Ministry of Agriculture and Forestry. The goals for Syke's performance, impact, and research quality are agreed upon in annual performance agreements and reported in the annual report. These goals include targets for the quality, performance, and impact of research and expert work. A key aspect of evaluating Syke's activities is societal impact: How has Syke contributed to building a sustainable society? How has Syke produced and disseminated information and solutions to promote the sustainability transformation?

The achievement of goals is measured using qualitative and quantitative indicators. Performance indicators track Syke's outputs, including the number and quality of peer-reviewed and other publications, the usage of data, and Syke's visibility in the media. Qualitative and quantitative indicators of societal impact aim to demonstrate the impact of Syke's research on various societal actors, for instance, as well as on planning and policy processes, and ultimately on the state of the environment. In some cases, Syke's impact has been evaluated through a separate external process.

In Syke's internal management, the goals, key activities, and desired impact of each unit are agreed upon annually to carry out the actions of the implementation programme of Syke's strategy. The units' goals are particularly related to advancing the key development areas of Syke's strategic objectives, thus relating to both impact and performance.

Table 1. Syke's research assessment levels.

Assessment level	What is evaluated?	Means	Goal
Organisational level	Syke's impact, performance, and research quality	- Goals are agreed upon in the performance agreement and internal management. - Qualitative and quantitative monitoring annually.	Monitoring, presentation, improvement of operations
Project level	Project's impact and performance	Mainly qualitative self-assessment at the end of the project.	Monitoring
	Efficiency of project management	Qualitative self-assessment form at the end of the project.	Improvement of operations
Researcher level	Suitability for the position (recruitment)	Evaluation by the supervisor and other key participants in the recruitment (external evaluation for professors), mainly qualitative.	Recruitment
	Achievement of personal goals (goal and development discussions)	- Setting and monitoring personal goals. - Annual evaluation. - Qualitative, with quantitative support. - In collaboration between the supervisor and the researcher.	Guidance, encouragement, professional development

Project level assessment

A significant amount of Syke's research is conducted through externally funded projects. When required, projects report their results and impacts directly to the funder according to the funder's guidelines. At Syke, the implementation, results, and impact of projects are primarily evaluated through projects' self-assessment. The summary information obtained from evaluations and reports is used to prepare the annual report, but it is not currently systematically reviewed at the overall Syke level. Additionally, projects evaluate the efficiency of their project management.

Researcher level assessment

Recruitment

Prospective researchers at Syke are evaluated during the recruitment process. The supervisor defines the key tasks, the needed competence, and the selection criteria used to assess and compare applicants. Typically, the selection criteria include the required education, work experience, and competence, as well as personal qualities that support the role. The job announcement describes the content of the relevant research field and closely links it to specific competence requirements. Additionally, Syke has a professor policy, according to which an external peer review is conducted for the recruitment of research professors based on established uniform evaluation criteria. The selection of a research professor is made by Syke's internal selection panel.

Annual goal and development discussions

According to Syke's salary system, an employee's salary is determined by the requirement level of the position, personal performance, and possible experience component. The job description and the

requirement level of the position are reviewed and, if necessary, defined during the annual goal and development discussion.

In the goal and development discussion, the supervisor and the researcher jointly set the researcher's goals for the following year, agree on the criteria for evaluating the achievement of these goals and their monitoring, and aim to set concrete indicators, such as the number of publications. Additionally, they discuss the needs and means for competence development. The supervisor and the researcher form a joint assessment of how the researcher has achieved the goals set for the previous year. Based on this joint assessment, the researcher's performance level may change which may also affect the actual salary.

Syke's goals and challenges in research assessment

Syke's goals for research and researcher assessment

Syke's goals for developing the assessment of research and researchers are as follows:

- Improve the quality and impact of Syke's research
- Develop the assessment of the quality, impact, and performance of Syke's research
- Strengthen the connection between the goals of the organization, projects, and researchers/staff
- Enhance the transparency and equality in research assessment
 - By promoting consistent practices
 - By considering the differences between scientific disciplines and the diversity of researcher careers and roles
- Ensure the competitiveness of Syke's research and researchers in changing assessment practices

Key Challenges

Syke already implements the principles of responsible research assessment quite well. The assessment focuses on societal impact goals and their achievement. Researchers are mainly evaluated qualitatively based on the achievement of their personal goals, with some quantitative goals for individual researchers. The challenges related to responsible assessment mainly involve taking into account diverse tasks and outputs, as well as ensuring the transparency and consistency of researcher assessment.

The most significant challenges we have identified relate more broadly to our own goal-setting and evaluation processes. A key challenge is how to implement organizational-level qualitative and quantitative goals in practice and how to align the different levels of evaluation (organization, project, researcher). Challenges include how organizational goals are reflected in the goals of researchers or projects and their evaluation, and defining which indicators are used at each level. Additionally, it is unclear whether the current set of indicators and knowledge base sufficiently capture the principles of responsible assessment.

The challenges in project assessment are indirectly related to responsible research assessment. Although a large part of Syke's outputs are generated in projects, the challenge is that the self-assessments are not conducted systematically and thus not sufficiently utilized in the development of research and other activities.

At Syke, research and expert work are conducted side by side, but the assessment of researchers does not currently sufficiently take into account the different researcher roles (research tasks) and diverse outputs. Another challenge is ensuring the fairness, consistency, and transparency of the qualitative evaluations conducted by supervisors, and linking the evaluation of work done in projects to the assessment of researchers.

Planned Actions

We have identified that achieving the goals and addressing the challenges at Syke does not require a major reform, but rather sharpening and improving our operations.

1 Review and management of Syke's performance, quality, and impact target levels

This action involves refining Syke's performance, quality, and impact targets and target levels annually. The strategic management group will regularly discuss improving performance, quality, and impact, and managing the achievement of these goals.

2 Review and definition of research assessment principles and indicators at different levels

2.1 Definition of responsible research assessment principles:

The general principles of responsible research assessment will be refined to be Syke-specific and, if necessary, published on Syke's external website along with Syke's open science principles. In addition, it will be explored how the commitment to responsible research assessment practices can be utilized when marketing Syke and building Syke's employer brand.

2.2 Specifying the research assessment indicators if necessary:

Syke's existing research assessment indicators will be reviewed to consider whether they currently sufficiently take into account the principles of responsible assessment. They will be refined if necessary to better consider diverse research tasks and outputs, as well as promoting an open operating culture.

2.3 Definition of goals and indicators at different evaluation levels:

The goals of Syke's strategy and targets set in the ministry's performance guidance will be more clearly linked to projects' goals and researchers' personal goals. It will be defined at which level - organization, project, researcher - each set goal and indicator will be examined. The possibility of forming broader project clusters and setting goals for clusters instead of individual projects will also be considered.

2.4 Clarification of different researcher roles and research tasks:

The descriptions of different researcher roles and research tasks used in the job descriptions and in the annual goal setting and monitoring will be reviewed and if needed refined to better address the principles of responsible assessment. Additionally, the selection criteria for researcher and professor recruitments will be refined.

3 Review and improvement of tools, guidelines, and practices

This action involves promoting the implementation of the matters agreed upon in point 2 by developing and refining guidelines, tools, and practices.

3.1 Complementing the guidelines related to researcher assessments:

Recruitment guidelines, goal and development discussion guidelines, and, if necessary, job description guidelines will be refined as agreed in point 2. The guidelines will make it clear how goals and indicators derive from organizational-level goals and indicators.

3.2 Improving the knowledge base of indicators if needed:

If it is determined in the action point 2 that new indicators are needed to diversify the evaluation and better consider responsible assessment, a process will be created to produce the desired indicators (outputs). If data for these indicators is not directly available from databases, the automatic import of data through interfaces and AI applications will be particularly promoted.

3.3. Developing the practices and tools for implementing organizational goals at the project and researcher levels:

The goals and indicators agreed upon in the action point 2 will be implemented at the project and researcher levels primarily by developing existing tools (such as the project management system, goal and development discussion platform, and project proposal sparring discussions).

3.4. Ensuring transparency and consistency:

In researcher recruitments, the transparency of evaluation and selection will be increased by using the selection criteria agreed upon in action point 2 and by describing the criteria, selection process, and responsible assessment practices on Syke's intranet and external website. The consistency of setting the annual goals for and assessing the performance of researchers will be increased by using the targets and indicators agreed upon in point 2, by discussing them in the supervisor forum, and by increasing other discussions related to assessment.

3.5. Developing projects' self-evaluation.

The existing practices for projects' self-evaluation will be developed, and consideration will be given to how the perspectives of responsible assessment can be better incorporated into self-evaluation. The self-evaluation form for project management efficiency will be renewed, and the form for project results and impact will be refined. The systematic completion and utilization of both self-evaluation forms will be promoted.

4 Staff engagement and collaborative learning

To integrate assessment principles, goals, indicators, guidelines, and tools into the daily activities of the staff, they will be designed in collaboration with the staff. Additionally, staff competence will be maintained through ongoing discussions.

4.1. Identifying challenges and development areas:

A survey will be conducted among researchers and experts to identify current challenges and development needs for Syke's research assessment. Based on this, the action plan will be revised if necessary.

4.2. Promoting discussion on Syke's research assessment:

Active discussions on the quality and impact of Syke's research and on developing the research assessment at Syke will be promoted. Discussions will be held through existing structures, and separate researcher workshops will be organized if necessary.

4.3. Strengthening and standardizing supervisory work in researcher assessment:

Transparent and consistent practices among supervisors concerning recruitments, job descriptions, and goal and development discussions will be strengthened by discussing the practices in the supervisor forum and facilitating other peer discussions.

4.4. Building competence and collaborating:

Information on responsible research assessment and its national and international developments will be shared within Syke. The existing knowledge at the researcher level will be made more widely available to the organization.

Syke will strengthen its expertise in responsible evaluation and share its practices by participating in the activities of CoARA and its national chapter, as well as other national working groups related to responsible assessment. Where possible, practices of international sister organizations will be explored.

5 Monitoring

The implementation and monitoring of the work will be the responsibility of a project team that includes the research director and personnel from research and human resources management. Other Syke experts will also be involved in the practical implementation of the work.

Progress will be reported annually in Syke's annual report.